SER O ESTAR
TWO VERBS, ONE WORD

not permanent vs temporary — that rule gets the hard ones backwards

1. Ask one question and it is not "how long will this last?"

SER

¿Qué es? — what *is* it?

Identity, category, definition. The thing itself: who it is, what it's made of, where it's from, when it happens. **Ser classifies.**

ESTAR

¿Cómo está? — what state is it *in*?

Condition, position, the result of something that happened. Not what it is — how it currently stands. **Estar describes a state.**

Why "permanent vs temporary" has to go — it gets all four of these the wrong way round:
Madrid **está** en España (a thousand years) · Hoy **es** lunes (24 hours) · La fiesta **es** en mi casa (one evening) · **Está** muerto (forever)

2. Ser — what the thing is facts that define it

identity	**Es** mi hermano. **Soy** Pierre.
origin	**Soy** sueco. El queso **es** de España.
job	**Es** médica. — no article after ser
whose	El libro **es** de mi padre.
material	La casa **es** de madera.
character	**Es** alto. **Son** simpáticos.
clock, date	**Son** las tres. Hoy **es** lunes.
the total	**Son** 9,50 €.
events	La fiesta **es** en mi casa. El examen **es** mañana.

3. Estar — the state it is in where it stands, and how it is right now

location	Madrid **está** en España. ¿Dónde **está** el baño?
condition	La sopa **está** fría. **Está** enfermo.
feeling	**Estoy** cansado pero **estoy** feliz.
after a change	La puerta **está** abierta.
-ing, right now	**Está** lloviendo. **Estoy** trabajando.
estar de	**Está** de vacaciones. **Está** de camarero. — working as one, for now

4. One adjective, two meanings here duration explains nothing at all — the verb *is* the meaning

	SER — WHAT IT IS	ESTAR — THE STATE IT'S IN
aburrido	**es aburrido** — boring	**está aburrido** — bored
listo	**es listo** — clever	**está listo** — ready
rico	**es rico** — wealthy	**está rico** — it tastes good
bueno	**es bueno** — a good person, good quality	**está bueno** — tasty · of a person, good-looking
malo	**es malo** — bad, wicked	**está malo** — ill · of food, off
verde	**es verde** — green, the colour	**está verde** — unripe
vivo	**es vivo** — sharp, lively	**está vivo** — alive

5. The two places it catches you both look like exceptions; neither is

Location splits in two.
A thing or a person sits somewhere → **estar**
¿Dónde **está** la casa? · Madrid **está** en España.
An event happens somewhere → **ser**
¿Dónde **es** la fiesta? · El concierto **es** en el parque.
The test: if English could say *takes place*, use **ser**.

estar + participle = the result.
Someone did it; this is how it ended up.
La puerta **está** abierta · **está** roto · **está** sentado · **está** dormido
está casado · **está** muerto — the two that make "permanent" collapse
These are states arrived at, which is why *estar* wins however long they last.

6. And sometimes it is neither **tener** takes over where English keeps saying *to be*

Tengo hambre · **sed** — I'm hungry · thirsty
Tengo frío · **calor** — I'm cold · hot
Tengo sueño — I'm sleepy
Tengo miedo · **prisa** — I'm afraid · in a hurry
Tengo veinte años — I'm twenty · never *soy veinte*
Tienes razón — you're right
and the weather is a third verb again:
Hace frío — the air · **tengo** frío — me · **está** frío — my coffee

If one line survives: **ser** says what a thing **is**, **estar** says what state it is **in**. Ask which you mean before you ask how long it lasts — *está muerto* lasts forever and *hoy es lunes* lasts a day.